

The FIFA World Cup

A Complete Reference Guide

History • Format & Rules • Complete Results (1930–2022) • Records & Trivia • Trophy & Awards •
Governing Body (FIFA)

Reference knowledge base compiled for retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) applications. Content reflects tournaments through the 2022 FIFA World Cup in Qatar, with confirmed format details for the 2026, 2030, and 2034 editions.

1. What is the FIFA World Cup?

The FIFA World Cup is an international men's football (soccer) tournament contested by the senior national teams of the member associations of FIFA (Fédération Internationale de Football Association), the sport's global governing body. It is held every four years, except in 1942 and 1946 when it was not held because of World War II. The FIFA World Cup is widely regarded as the most prestigious and widely viewed sporting event in the world, with an estimated cumulative global audience of over 3.5 billion people for the 2018 tournament.

The current champion, as of the 2022 tournament, is **Argentina**, who won their third title by defeating France in the final on penalties.

There is a separate competition for women's national teams called the FIFA Women's World Cup, first held in 1991, and separate global youth and club competition structures. This document focuses on the men's FIFA World Cup.

2. History and Origins

- The idea of a global football championship organized by FIFA was pushed forward by FIFA President Jules Rimet in the late 1920s.
- The first FIFA World Cup was held in **1930 in Uruguay**. Uruguay was chosen partly because it was the reigning Olympic football champion and was celebrating its centennial of independence. Uruguay won the inaugural tournament, defeating Argentina 4–2 in the final.
- Only 13 teams participated in the 1930 World Cup, mostly from the Americas and a small number of European teams who made the long sea voyage.
- The tournament was not held in 1942 or 1946 due to World War II.
- The original trophy was called the **Jules Rimet Trophy**, named after the FIFA president who initiated the competition. Brazil was awarded permanent possession of the Jules Rimet Trophy in 1970 after winning their third title, per the rules of the time. The trophy was later stolen in Brazil in 1983 and never recovered, believed to have been melted down.
- Since 1974, the winning team receives the current **FIFA World Cup Trophy**, a solid gold and malachite trophy. Unlike the Jules Rimet Trophy, the current trophy is never given away permanently — winners keep it until the next tournament and receive a gold-plated replica to keep.

3. Format of the FIFA World Cup

3.1 Qualification

- Nearly all of FIFA's member associations (over 200) enter a qualification process that runs for nearly three years before the final tournament.
- Qualification is organized separately by each of FIFA's six continental confederations: UEFA (Europe), CONMEBOL (South America), CONCACAF (North/Central America and Caribbean), CAF (Africa), AFC (Asia), and OFC (Oceania).

- Each confederation is allocated a certain number of guaranteed slots in the final tournament, plus intercontinental play-off spots for borderline qualifiers.
- The host nation(s) automatically qualify for the final tournament without going through qualifiers.

3.2 Final Tournament Structure (used from 1998–2022, 32-team format)

- 32 national teams qualified for the final tournament.
- Teams were divided into 8 groups of 4 (Groups A through H) via a seeding process and draw.
- **Group stage:** Each team played the other three teams in its group once (round-robin). Points: 3 for a win, 1 for a draw, 0 for a loss. The top 2 teams from each group advanced to the knockout stage. Ties were broken by goal difference, goals scored, head-to-head results, and other tiebreakers such as fair play points.
- **Knockout stage (Round of 16 onward):** Single-elimination matches. If level after 90 minutes, 30 minutes of extra time was played; if still level, a penalty shoot-out decided the match.
- The knockout stage consisted of: Round of 16 → Quarter-finals → Semi-finals → Final, plus a third-place play-off between the two losing semi-finalists.
- The total tournament typically ran about one month, featuring 64 matches.

3.3 New Format Starting in 2026

- Beginning with the **2026 FIFA World Cup**, hosted jointly by the **United States, Mexico, and Canada**, the tournament expanded from 32 to **48 teams**.
- The 48 teams are divided into **12 groups of 4**. The top 2 teams from each group, plus the 8 best third-placed teams, advance (32 teams total) to a new knockout round of 32.
- This produces a longer tournament with 104 total matches, up from 64.
- The expansion to 48 teams was approved by the FIFA Congress in 2017 and confirmed for implementation starting in 2026.
- The 2026 World Cup is the first men's World Cup to be hosted by three countries simultaneously, and is scheduled for June 11 – July 19, 2026.

3.4 Match Rules Specific to the World Cup

- Standard match length is 90 minutes (two 45-minute halves), plus stoppage/injury time added at the referee's discretion.
- In knockout stages, if scores are level after 90 minutes, two 15-minute periods of extra time are played (30 minutes total).
- If still level after extra time, the match is decided by a penalty shoot-out (best of 5 penalties per team, followed by sudden-death rounds if still tied).
- The Video Assistant Referee (VAR) system was first introduced at a FIFA World Cup in **2018 in Russia** and is used to review goals, penalties, red cards, and mistaken identity.
- Goal-line technology was first used at the World Cup in **2014 in Brazil**.

4. Complete List of FIFA World Cup Tournaments and Winners

Year	Host	Winner	Runner-up	Score (Final)
1930	Uruguay	Uruguay	Argentina	4-2
1934	Italy	Italy	Czechoslovakia	2-1 (a.e.t.)
1938	France	Italy	Hungary	4-2
1942	Not held (WWII)	-	-	-
1946	Not held (WWII)	-	-	-
1950	Brazil	Uruguay	Brazil	Final round-robin (2-1)
1954	Switzerland	West Germany	Hungary	3-2
1958	Sweden	Brazil	Sweden	5-2
1962	Chile	Brazil	Czechoslovakia	3-1
1966	England	England	West Germany	4-2 (a.e.t.)
1970	Mexico	Brazil	Italy	4-1
1974	West Germany	West Germany	Netherlands	2-1
1978	Argentina	Argentina	Netherlands	3-1 (a.e.t.)
1982	Spain	Italy	West Germany	3-1
1986	Mexico	Argentina	West Germany	3-2
1990	Italy	West Germany	Argentina	1-0
1994	United States	Brazil	Italy	0-0 (pens 3-2)
1998	France	France	Brazil	3-0
2002	South Korea / Japan	Brazil	Germany	2-0
2006	Germany	Italy	France	1-1 (pens 5-3)
2010	South Africa	Spain	Netherlands	1-0 (a.e.t.)
2014	Brazil	Germany	Argentina	1-0 (a.e.t.)
2018	Russia	France	Croatia	4-2
2022	Qatar	Argentina	France	3-3 (pens 4-2)
2026	USA / Mexico / Canada	Scheduled Jun 11-Jul 19, 2026 (48 teams)	-	-

Note: "a.e.t." means "after extra time." The 1950 final was not a single match but the deciding game of a final group stage; it is commonly referred to as the "Maracanazo" because host nation Brazil lost to Uruguay in front of a home crowd of nearly 200,000 at the Maracanã Stadium.

5. Titles Won by Country (through 2022)

Country	Titles	Years Won
Brazil	5	1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, 2002
Germany (incl. West Germany)	4	1954, 1974, 1990, 2014
Italy	4	1934, 1938, 1982, 2006
Argentina	3	1978, 1986, 2022
France	2	1998, 2018
Uruguay	2	1930, 1950
England	1	1966
Spain	1	2010

Brazil is the only country to have played in every single FIFA World Cup tournament since the first one in 1930.

6. Notable Records and Facts

Team Records

- **Most World Cup titles:** Brazil, with 5 (1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, 2002).
- **Most consecutive titles:** Italy (1934, 1938) and Brazil (1958, 1962) each won back-to-back titles.
- **Most final appearances:** Germany, with 8 finals.
- **Only team to appear in every World Cup:** Brazil.
- **Biggest winning margin in a match:** Hungary defeated El Salvador 10–1 in 1982; also Yugoslavia beat Zaire 9–0 in 1974.

Individual Records

- **All-time top scorer (World Cup history):** Miroslav Klose (Germany), with 16 goals across the 2002, 2006, 2010, and 2014 tournaments.
- **Most goals in a single tournament:** Just Fontaine (France), 13 goals, in the 1958 World Cup — still an unbroken record.
- **Most World Cup appearances by a player:** Lionel Messi (Argentina) and Lothar Matthäus (Germany) each played in 26 World Cup matches across 5 tournaments (Messi: 2006, 2010, 2014, 2018, 2022).
- **Youngest World Cup winner:** Pelé (Brazil) won his first title in 1958 at age 17, and remains the youngest player to score in a World Cup final.
- **Only player to win the World Cup three times:** Pelé (Brazil), in 1958, 1962, and 1970.
- **Fastest goal in World Cup history:** Hakan Şükür (Turkey) scored just 10.8 seconds into a match against South Korea in 2002.
- **Notable goalkeeping record:** Essam El-Hadary (Egypt) saved a penalty at age 45 in 2018, becoming the oldest player ever to feature in a World Cup match.

7. FIFA World Cup Trophy and Awards

The Trophy

- The current **FIFA World Cup Trophy** has been awarded since 1974. It is made of 18-karat gold with a malachite base, stands 36.8 cm tall, and weighs approximately 6.1 kg.
- It depicts two human figures holding up the Earth.
- The winning nation keeps the trophy until the next World Cup and receives a gold-plated bronze replica permanently.

End-of-Tournament Awards

- **Golden Ball:** Awarded to the best overall player of the tournament (runner-up gets Silver Ball, third place gets Bronze Ball).

- **Golden Boot (Golden Shoe):** Awarded to the tournament's top goalscorer.
- **Golden Glove:** Awarded to the best goalkeeper of the tournament.
- **Best Young Player Award:** Given to the best player aged 21 or under.
- **FIFA Fair Play Award:** Given to the team with the best disciplinary record and fair play conduct.

Recent Award Winners (2022, Qatar)

- Golden Ball: Lionel Messi (Argentina)
- Golden Boot: Kylian Mbappé (France), 8 goals
- Golden Glove: Emiliano Martínez (Argentina)
- Best Young Player: Enzo Fernández (Argentina)

Recent Award Winners (2018, Russia)

- Golden Ball: Luka Modrić (Croatia)
- Golden Boot: Harry Kane (England), 6 goals
- Golden Glove: Thibaut Courtois (Belgium)
- Best Young Player: Kylian Mbappé (France)

8. Governing Body: FIFA

- FIFA (Fédération Internationale de Football Association) is the international governing body of football, founded in **1904** in Paris, France.
- FIFA is headquartered in **Zurich, Switzerland**.
- FIFA organizes the World Cup and numerous other tournaments, including the Women's World Cup, U-20 and U-17 World Cups, the Confederations Cup (discontinued after 2017), FIFA Club World Cup, and futsal and beach soccer world championships.
- FIFA has over 200 member associations, more than the United Nations has member states.

The Six Continental Confederations

Confederation	Region
UEFA	Europe
CONMEBOL	South America
CONCACAF	North America, Central America, and the Caribbean
CAF	Africa
AFC	Asia
OFC	Oceania

9. Host Selection

- Host countries are selected by a vote of the FIFA Congress (previously the FIFA Executive Committee), typically many years in advance.
- The 2018 and 2022 hosts (Russia and Qatar) were both selected in a single vote in December 2010, awarded years ahead of schedule.
- The 2026 World Cup, hosted by the United States, Mexico, and Canada, will mark the first time Mexico has hosted three World Cups (1970, 1986, 2026) and will be the first World Cup held across three nations.
- The 2030 FIFA World Cup is scheduled to be hosted jointly by Morocco, Spain, and Portugal, with special centennial matches also planned in Uruguay, Argentina, and Paraguay to mark 100 years since the first World Cup in 1930.
- The 2034 FIFA World Cup is scheduled to be hosted by Saudi Arabia.

10. Interesting Trivia

- The term "soccer" originated in England as slang for "association football," to distinguish it from rugby football; it is mainly used today in the United States, Canada, and Australia, while the rest of the world calls it "football."
- The famous "Hand of God" goal was scored by Diego Maradona (Argentina) against England in the 1986 World Cup quarter-final, where he punched the ball into the net; the same match also featured his "Goal of the Century," a mazy dribble past five England players.
- The 1950 World Cup match between host Brazil and Uruguay, decisive for the title, remains one of the most attended football matches ever, with an estimated crowd of around 173,000–200,000 at the Maracanã Stadium — a result so shocking to the host nation it is remembered in Brazil as the "Maracanazo."
- Germany's 7–1 victory over host nation Brazil in the 2014 semi-final is one of the most stunning results in World Cup history and is often referred to in Brazil as the "Mineirazo" (after the Estádio Mineirão where it was played).
- The World Cup trophy cannot be kept permanently by any team anymore (unlike the original Jules Rimet Trophy, which Brazil kept forever after their third title in 1970).
- North Korea's unexpected win over Italy in 1966 remains one of the biggest upsets in World Cup history.
- Senegal became the first African nation to reach a World Cup quarter-final, doing so in their debut tournament appearance in 2002, defeating defending champions France in the opening match.